

assaulted by almost 50 men in spite of being accompanied by a man. Even my colleagues have shared some horrific experiences with me. So I am constantly on guard. A girl travelling late at night always attracts unwanted attention. Women have to look after their own safety; the administration cannot help us.

So I make sure I have company when travelling late at night. If I am alone in an autorickshaw, I sit in the middle. I try to keep my

## "I don't trust the public transport system when it is late at night."

**I**s my city safe? Well, I had almost always thought that Kolkata was one of the safest cities to live in till I went through a harrowing experience. I run a PR firm. You would think I am an independent, enterprising woman. Yes, even I think so. Yet for years I was unable to even talk about what happened to me in 1999.

and would have done the same to me. But I just kept pleading with them that I was pregnant and begged them to let us go. They hurled abuses at us, saying our car had hit a chair kept outside their pandal. Nothing of the sort had happened but fortunately, they let us go. The trauma was so severe that I had a miscarriage. Scared out of our minds, we did not even report it to the police.

A few days ago when I was reading of Soumya Viswanathan's death, this incident came back to me. We were lucky in a way, though only I can feel the loss. Due to my work, I often need to be out late, attending meetings, and even late night parties that are part of my job. I know Kolkata well and feel perfectly at home. But even after working for nearly 13 years, I take precautions. Safety is a concern I address on a daily basis and I always have my own car and chauffeur. I don't trust the public transport system and when it is late, I don't feel safe getting into a taxi. I make sure that any woman working late hours in my office gets a car to go home. Even then, there are times I am scared to be out alone at nights. Once, after an event, I was waiting outside a five-star hotel on Park Street for a taxi and a car stopped right in front of me. The man inside opened the door and ordered me to get in. It was only 7.30 p.m. His intentions were obvious. Thankfully, I just moved away. But not everyone has that option every time.

**as told to Elora Sen**

**SOMINI SEN DUA, 35, RUNS A PR FIRM, KOLKATA**



SUVASHIS MULLICK

parents informed about my whereabouts; I call them every time I leave work for home, or even when I am out with friends. Instead of driving my own vehicle I prefer to use public transport. And yes, if I forget, there is always the scar on my wrist.

**as told to Nikita Jain**

I was pregnant then, and out with my husband to celebrate his birthday. We were on our way back from a five-star hotel at 11 p.m. That's when we were chased by a gang of seven drunken men in an Ambassador with a government number-plate. They caught up with our Zen, dragged my husband out,

January 2008 Two women were molested by over 50 men outside a hotel on New Year's day. Fourteen arrests were made in the case.

December 2007 Nine air hostesses, working with Lufthansa, were attacked by four drunken men. The men were arrested.